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# BRICS after the Durban and Fortaleza summits

Niall Reddy

Unlike in Durban in March 2013, the conclusion of the BRICS summit in Fortaleza was greeted with massive international media attention. The ostensible source of this renewed interest, following months of bad press for emerging markets, was the birth of the New Development Bank (NDB) and a US$100 billion Contingent Reserve Arrangement ('CRA') between member nations. Suddenly BRICS seemed to be more than a catchy acronym for investors and challenging critics who charge that the alliance is contentless and largely incoherent.

BRICS also started to appear as a geopolitical presence during the Syria crisis when the US threatened a bombing of the Assad regime, the Ukraine crisis, acting against Western attempts to punish Russia through sanctions and its eviction from the G8 and G20. China's growing dominance of world trade and the increased assertiveness of Brazil and India, leading a coalition of developing countries, together seem to have disrupted the ability of the US and its allies to shape the global trade regime. US and EU bickering caused the collapse of the Doha round of agreements at the WTO. Taken along with international investment, trade and GDP figures, there seems to be ample evidence of a shift in the coordinates of global power. BRICS nations have tended to embrace the narrative of emerging powers, often adopting the grammar of post-war Third Worldism with talk of a 'new world order'.

But on closer examination, the agreements actually inked at Fortaleza hardly represent a radical challenge to the existing state of affairs. The CRA, touted by many as an important step in freeing developing nations from dependency on the IMF, actually replicates the latter's control – requiring borrowers to prove